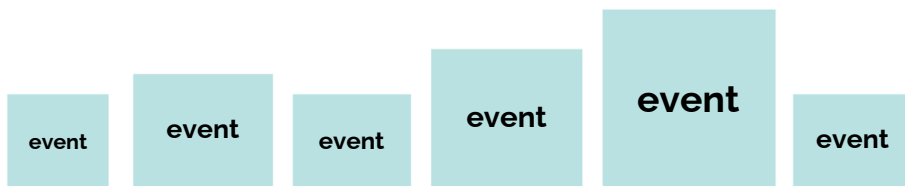




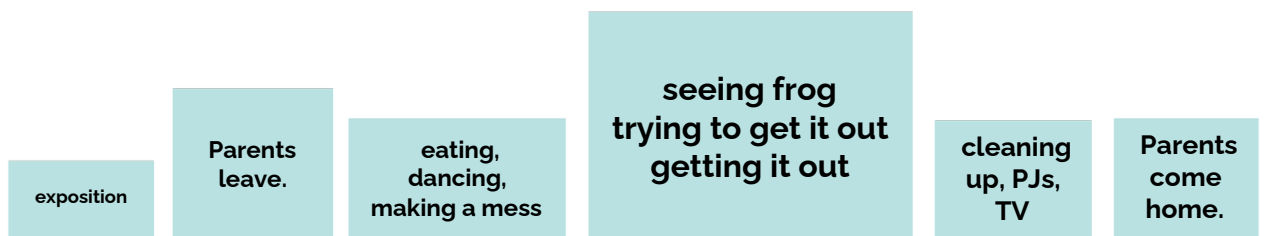
PACING



Rather than presenting events as they are, it amplifies certain aspects to create a more dramatic effect while minimizing the significance of less important details.



Here's how it looks for the story *Frog*.⁷ It starts with some exposition about why the character never gets to stay at home, then shows the parents leaving. Next, we see the character eating, dancing, and making a mess in the house—this part is a little longer, because she's really enjoying her time alone.



Next is the biggest part, where she sees the frog, tries a few things to get it out, and finally gets it out. Because this part is the most dramatic, it takes up a big part of the story.

Once that's over, she cleans up, gets into her pajamas, and watches TV. This part is not so dramatic, so it's quicker. Finally, her parents come home. At this point, the story is just about done, so this part doesn't take up a lot of time, either.

The story employs varied narrative techniques:

- The exposition is summarized.
- The parents' decision to leave is presented as a full scene with dialogue.
- The character's chaotic behavior is summarized rather than detailed.
- The significant "frog" scene is slow, emphasizing time.
- The cleanup is summarized again.

The parents' return is depicted as a scene.



At three different times in the story, we also see a break in time: After the parents leave, there's a jump ahead in time, then another one after she gets rid of the frog, and another one between her settling back down and when her parents come home. All of those breaks are there because readers don't need to see every minute. Some chunks of time just aren't interesting, so you can jump over them to get to the more interesting parts.

Crafting Your Short Story

Consider a short story you'd like to share. Identify the events that require more detail versus those that can be briefly mentioned.

- Begin by creating a list or sequence of events.
- Rank them based on their significance to the plot using a diagram, allocating more space to the most crucial elements.

Reflect on which portions will become scenes and which can simply be summarized, and identify where you might incorporate time breaks.